

UNIT 1: MY COMPANY

READING — INSIDE NEXABYTE SOLUTIONS

A company with a clear purpose

NexaByte Solutions is a fictional IT company based in Zaragoza. It provides digital services for small and medium-sized businesses across Aragón. Its clients include shops, hotels, training centres and transport companies. These organisations have different needs, but they share one problem: they need technology that works reliably and is easy to use.

NexaByte has eighteen employees. Some develop software, while others maintain networks or provide technical support. The company does not manufacture computers. Instead, it helps clients choose suitable equipment, connect their devices and use digital tools effectively.

Before starting a project, the team meets the client. They ask questions about the business, its current problems and its budget. A small shop might need a website, while a hotel might need a more reliable wireless network. The company proposes a solution after understanding the situation.

Who does what?

The company has four departments: software development, network services, technical support and administration.

Marta is the project manager. She organises tasks, agrees deadlines with clients and checks progress. She does not write all the code or install every device. Her job is to make sure that the different teams work together.

The developers create websites and applications. Before writing code, they discuss the requirements with the client. They need to know what the application must do and who will use it. A developer also tests the software and corrects errors before delivering the final version.

The network administrator manages the company's network and helps design networks for clients. He checks connections, configures equipment and controls access to shared resources. The support technicians help users with everyday problems, such as forgotten passwords, software errors or printers that do not work.

The administration team prepares invoices, organises appointments and answers general enquiries. Although its members do not develop software, their work is essential: clear communication helps technical projects run smoothly.

The workplace

NexaByte's office has a reception area, an open workspace, two meeting rooms and a small server room. The meeting rooms are next to reception, so visitors do not need to walk through the main workspace.

Each workstation has a computer, two monitors, a keyboard and a headset. Employees use the headsets for online meetings and support calls. There is also a quiet area where they can concentrate on difficult tasks.

The server room contains equipment that supports internal services. Access is restricted to authorised staff. Employees must not leave the door open or allow visitors to enter without permission.

The company uses a shared digital workspace to organise documents and project information. However, not every employee can open every file. Access permissions depend on each person's responsibilities.

A new project

This month, NexaByte is working with a local bicycle shop called GreenWheel. The shop currently receives repair bookings by telephone and records them in a paper diary. This sometimes causes problems: staff cannot always read the notes, and customers occasionally receive incorrect appointment times.

GreenWheel wants a web application that allows customers to request appointments online. The application must show available times, record contact details and send a confirmation message. Staff also need to update the booking calendar.

Two developers are building the application. A designer is preparing a clear interface, and a support technician is checking the shop's computers and internet connection. Marta is organising a short meeting every Tuesday to review progress.

The team is not adding online payments to the first version. The client has a limited budget, so the first priority is a reliable booking system. Extra features can come later.

From requirements to delivery

The team begins with a list of requirements. Then it creates a prototype to show the main screens and how users move between them. The client can comment on the design before the developers build the complete application.

The application stores booking information in a database. Customers create an account and use a password to access their bookings. Staff members have different access permissions because they need to manage appointments.

Before delivery, the team tests the application. They check whether users can book a time, change their details and cancel an appointment. They also test what happens when someone enters incomplete information.

Security is part of the project from the beginning. The team installs updates, checks access permissions and plans regular backups. A backup can help recover information if data is lost, but it does not prevent every security problem.

Finally, the company provides a short training session for the shop's employees. A successful delivery means that the application works and that the staff know how to use it.

Joining the team

Alex is a new trainee at NexaByte. On his first morning, his supervisor explains the company's services and introduces him to his colleagues. Alex receives an account, but he does not immediately have access to all client systems.

At first, he checks support tickets with an experienced technician. Each ticket describes a user's problem and records the actions taken. Alex learns to ask clear questions, write useful notes and explain solutions without unnecessary technical language.

If he cannot solve a problem, he asks a colleague for help. He must not make changes to a client's system without permission. Technical knowledge matters, but so do teamwork, responsibility and communication.

At the end of the week, Alex helps update the company website. He writes a short description of the support department and checks it with his supervisor. He is beginning to understand that an IT company needs more than good equipment: it needs people who can work together and understand their clients.

A. UNDERSTANDING THE TEXT

Answer in complete sentences where possible.

- 1. Where is NexaByte based, and what types of organisations does it work with?**

NexaByte is based in Zaragoza and serves small and medium-sized businesses across Aragón, including shops, hotels, training centres and transport companies.

- 2. What does the company do instead of manufacturing computers?**

Rather than manufacturing hardware, the company advises clients on choosing suitable equipment, connecting their devices and making effective use of digital tools.

- 3. Why does the team meet the client before proposing a solution?**

The team meets the client first in order to understand the nature of the business, its current problems and its budget, so that the solution it proposes is tailored to the client's actual situation.

- 4. What are the company's four departments?**

The company is organised into four departments: software development, network services, technical support and administration.

- 5. What are two of Marta's responsibilities?**

As project manager, Marta organises tasks and agrees deadlines with clients. She also monitors progress and ensures that the different teams work together effectively.

6. Why do developers discuss requirements before writing code?

They need to establish what the application must do and who will be using it; without that information, they could not build something that meets the client's needs.

7. Where are the meeting rooms?

The meeting rooms are located next to reception, so visitors can reach them without having to cross the main workspace.

8. Why do employees have different access permissions?

Access permissions are granted according to each person's responsibilities, which means that employees can only open the files that are relevant to their role.

9. What problems does GreenWheel have with its current booking method?

Because bookings are taken by telephone and noted down in a paper diary, staff cannot always read the entries, and customers occasionally end up with incorrect appointment times.

10. What must the new application allow customers to do?

It must allow customers to request appointments online. To do so, it has to display the available times, record their contact details and send a confirmation message.

11. Why is the team not including online payments in the first version?

The client's budget is limited, so the priority is a reliable booking system. Additional features, such as online payments, can be introduced at a later stage.

12. What is the purpose of the prototype?

The prototype shows the main screens and how users move between them, which allows the client to comment on the design before the developers build the complete application.

13. Where does the application store booking information?

The application stores booking information in a database.

14. What does the team test before delivery? Give two examples.

Before delivery, the team checks that users can book a time, change their details and cancel an appointment. It also tests how the application behaves when someone submits incomplete information.

15. Why does NexaByte provide training for GreenWheel's employees?

Because a delivery is only considered successful if the application works and the staff know how to use it, the company offers a short training session to the shop's employees.

16. What does Alex do if he cannot solve a problem?

If he cannot resolve a problem on his own, Alex asks a colleague for help instead of making changes to a client's system without permission.

B. TRUE OR FALSE?

Decide whether each statement is true or false. Correct the false statements.

1. NexaByte works only with shops.

False. NexaByte works with a variety of clients, not just shops: its customers also include hotels, training centres and transport companies.

2. Marta personally writes all the code for every project.

False. Marta does not write all the code; as project manager, her role is to coordinate the teams and make sure they work together.

3. Visitors can enter the server room whenever they want.

False. Access to the server room is restricted to authorised staff, and employees must not let visitors in without permission.

4. GreenWheel currently records bookings in a paper diary.

True.

5. The team reviews the GreenWheel project every Tuesday.

True.

6. A backup prevents every security problem.

False. A backup can help recover information if data is lost, but it cannot prevent every security problem.

7. Alex works with an experienced technician at first.

True.

8. Alex can change a client's system without permission.

False. Alex must not make any changes to a client's system without permission.